

FREE RESOURCE

European T&E; Implementation Checklist

47 things most organisations miss before go-live — from vendor evaluation to hypercare planning. Built from operational experience across 10+ European markets.

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This checklist covers the 47 actions most commonly missed — or left too late — in European T&E; platform implementations. It is organised by programme phase, from vendor evaluation through 90-day post-go-live adoption review.

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Work through each phase sequentially. For each item, record the status (Not started · In progress · Complete · N/A) and the owner. The *Why it matters* note explains the consequence of skipping that step — drawn from programmes that skipped it.

47 items

5 phases

10+ markets

Free download

PHASE 1 — VENDOR EVALUATION & SELECTION

Items 1–9

01 Define selection criteria before approaching vendors

Document functional requirements, integration needs, European market coverage, language support, and compliance capabilities before issuing the RFP.

Why it matters: Vendors shape their responses around what they know you are measuring. Define criteria first and the RFP process produces comparable, honest responses.

02 Require country-specific compliance evidence

Ask each vendor to confirm regulatory compliance for every target country: German receipts policy, French CSE obligations, Spanish IVA reporting, Dutch representation expense rules.

Why it matters: Compliance gaps found after contract signature are change requests. Found during evaluation, they are deal-breakers — at no cost.

03 Test the integration with your ERP in the RFP, not after

Require a technical proof-of-concept or reference call with a client using the same ERP before final selection.

Why it matters: Vendor integration promises made during sales rarely survive contact with your actual technical environment. Verify before you commit.

04 Score vendors on implementation support, not just platform features

Evaluate the quality of the implementation team and methodology — not just the platform. Ask for CVs of the actual implementation consultants assigned to your project.

Why it matters: The platform is what you buy. The implementation team is what delivers it. These are not the same quality level at the same vendor.

05 Validate multilingual support in practice, not in the brochure

Request demonstrations in each target language. Check whether localisation extends to error messages, training materials, and support documentation — not just the UI.

Why it matters: A platform 'available in French' but with English-only error messages and training materials will not achieve adoption in French-speaking markets.

06 Ask explicitly about the data migration methodology

Request a detailed data migration plan covering source systems, field mapping, validation rules, reconciliation approach, and what happens to historical data.

Why it matters: Data migration is consistently underestimated. A vendor without a clear methodology is signalling that it will be your problem to solve post-contract.

07 Review the standard contract's liability and change request clauses

Before signing, have legal review clauses covering scope change requests, go-live delay liability, and data ownership post-termination.

Why it matters: Standard vendor contracts are written to protect the vendor. The clauses that matter most are not in the sales materials.

08 Require references from comparable European programmes

Ask for references from clients who have delivered the same number of countries and entities as your programme — not single-country deployments.

Why it matters: A vendor experienced in single-country rollouts faces genuinely different challenges in a pan-European programme. The reference base should reflect that scope.

09 Confirm hypercare SLA terms before signature

Define the hypercare period, response time commitments, and what constitutes a critical incident in writing — before contract execution.

Why it matters: Hypercare terms negotiated after go-live, when you need them, will reflect the vendor's leverage, not yours.

PHASE 2 — PROGRAMME DESIGN & GOVERNANCE

Items 10–18

10 Appoint an internal programme owner with adoption accountability

Designate one person accountable not just for go-live but for adoption metrics at 30, 60, and 90 days post-go-live. This role is separate from the project manager.

Why it matters: When go-live is the only milestone, the programme ends on the day adoption work begins. Accountability for adoption must be built in from the start.

11 Establish a steering committee with cross-functional membership

Include Finance, HR, Legal, Procurement, and IT from the outset. Decisions that exclude any of these functions become change requests later.

Why it matters: In pan-European programmes, the most expensive changes are ones where a function that was not in the room discovers a constraint three months into implementation.

12 Design the travel and expense policy before platform configuration begins

Run the policy design workstream in parallel with vendor selection. Configuration built around an agreed policy is always cheaper than configuration built around a draft that keeps changing.

Why it matters: Every policy change after configuration begins is a change request. The policy workstream is not a communications task — it is a programme design dependency.

13 Document the regulatory requirements for each country before design begins

Run structured discovery sessions per country covering tax law, employment law, works council requirements, and any mandatory consultation processes.

Why it matters: Country-specific requirements discovered during UAT require configuration changes under time pressure. Discovered during design, they shape the configuration from the start.

14 Map the integration dependencies before the project plan is finalised

Identify every system the new platform needs to connect to: ERP, HR, payroll, travel booking tool, corporate card provider, identity management.

Why it matters: Integration scope is the most reliably underestimated element of any finance system implementation. Map it before the timeline is set.

15 Define data quality standards and acceptance criteria before migration

Agree on what constitutes 'clean' data for each migrated field, what the reconciliation process is, and who signs off on migration quality.

Why it matters: Migrated data that does not meet quality standards at go-live creates immediate user trust issues. This is not recoverable through communication.

16 Build a RACI matrix covering every major workstream decision

Define who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, and Informed for: policy changes, configuration decisions, country rollout sequencing, go-live sign-off, and post-go-live escalation.

Why it matters: In multi-entity programmes, decisions stall when it is unclear who has authority to make them. A RACI matrix removes that ambiguity before it costs time.

17 Agree the go-live readiness criteria before the project plan is signed off

Define explicitly what must be true for go-live to proceed: test pass rates, user readiness scores, data migration reconciliation sign-off, hypercare team confirmation.

Why it matters: Go-live criteria agreed under pressure, close to the go-live date, reflect the schedule rather than the readiness. Agree them early and treat them as non-negotiable.

18 Schedule a formal mid-programme health check

At the midpoint of the implementation, run a structured review of programme status, risks, and any scope changes that have accumulated since kick-off.

Why it matters: Scope creep in a six-month programme accumulates quietly. A mid-programme health check surfaces it before it becomes a timeline crisis.

PHASE 3 — CHANGE MANAGEMENT & TRAINING

Items 19–31

19 Identify and brief local champions before communications begin

Select one credible, trusted person per country or major business unit who will be the first point of contact for colleagues. Brief them before any central communications are sent.

Why it matters: Central communications land differently through a trusted local voice. A champion network is the primary adoption mechanism in multi-country programmes.

20 Brief local management before central communications reach employees

In France and Spain particularly, managers who hear about a change from their teams rather than from their leadership will undermine the programme — not deliberately, but inevitably.

Why it matters: Management credibility is a change management asset. Protecting it requires sequencing communications so managers are always ahead of the information flow.

21 Design training for each role, not for all users

Finance approvers, frequent travellers, occasional submitters, and finance reviewers have different interactions with the system. One training session for all users serves none of them well.

Why it matters: Role-specific training is more expensive to produce. It is also the only kind that produces competent users.

22 Deliver training in the local language for every non-English market

Translated training materials reviewed by a native speaker — not machine-translated and shipped. Training delivered in a second language reduces retention significantly.

Why it matters: A user who cannot follow training clearly in their own language will not be proficient at go-live. Language is not a cosmetic issue in change management — it is a competence issue.

23 Schedule training no earlier than two weeks before go-live

Training delivered more than two weeks before go-live is largely forgotten by the time the system is live. Schedule it close enough to be relevant.

Why it matters: Learning retention without reinforcement drops to approximately 10% within a week. Training three weeks before go-live is a compliance exercise, not a capability programme.

24 Conduct a practice environment session before go-live training

Give users access to a sandbox environment to practice real scenarios before the go-live training session. Arrive-and-learn produces anxiety; arrive-and-consolidate produces competence.

Why it matters: Users who have already attempted the system before training ask better questions, retain more, and arrive at go-live with more confidence.

25 Create a post-go-live quick reference guide for each user group

A one-page quick reference covering the five most common tasks for each user role, in the local language, available in the system and as a printable PDF.

Why it matters: Users who cannot find how to do something in the first week will use the old process instead. A quick reference guide reduces the friction of the transition period.

26 Establish a local-language feedback channel before go-live

A dedicated channel — email, chat, or SharePoint page — in each local language, monitored by the local champion, with a committed response time.

Why it matters: Feedback submitted in English by non-native speakers is systematically incomplete. A local-language channel produces better signal about what is going wrong.

27 Prepare a resistance management plan for each market

Identify the most likely sources of resistance — by role, by country, by function — and plan the interventions before resistance materialises.

Why it matters: Resistance is predictable. The finance team that has been doing manual reconciliation for ten years will resist a system that automates it. Planning for it is cheaper than reacting to it.

28 Define adoption metrics and share them with the steering committee before go-live

Submit rate by country, out-of-policy rate, processing time, and support ticket volume. Agree the 30-day and 60-day thresholds that would trigger intervention.

Why it matters: Adoption metrics agreed before go-live produce accountability. Agreed after a problem surfaces, they produce post-rationalisation.

29 Communicate what will not change as clearly as what will

Employees who are uncertain about which parts of their current process are being replaced often avoid the new system entirely to avoid making a mistake.

Why it matters: Uncertainty about scope — what is changing and what is staying the same — is one of the most common and most preventable causes of resistance.

30 Schedule a 30-day post-go-live communication from senior leadership

A brief message from the CFO or relevant senior leader, acknowledging the go-live and reinforcing the expectation that the new system is now the standard process.

Why it matters: Senior sponsorship after go-live signals that the change is permanent. Without it, users wait to see if the programme team reverts to the old process when adoption falters.

31 Plan for the second wave of training

New joiners after go-live, users absent during initial training, and markets going live in later phases all need training that is not a repurposed version of the pre-go-live materials.

Why it matters: Training infrastructure that ends at go-live means adoption degrades as staff changes over time. The new system should have a sustainable onboarding path, not just a launch programme.

PHASE 4 — TECHNICAL READINESS

Items 32–39

32 Complete UAT with real data, not synthetic test data

Run user acceptance testing using anonymised real expense data from the past six months. Test against the edge cases that actually occur in your organisation.

Why it matters: Synthetic test data produces a false sense of readiness. Real data surfaces the mapping exceptions, encoding issues, and edge cases that will appear on day one of go-live.

33 Test the integration fail state as well as the success state

Run test scenarios for every integration failure mode: ERP connection timeout, batch failure, duplicate submission, and out-of-sequence processing.

Why it matters: Most UAT tests the happy path. Go-live failures almost always involve the unhappy path — the edge case that was not tested because it was not expected.

34 Verify automated alerting for every critical failure point

Confirm that operations teams are automatically notified if the nightly batch fails, if the ERP integration produces a reconciliation break, or if the system is unavailable.

Why it matters: A failure discovered by a user report the following morning was not a technical failure — it was a monitoring failure.

35 Complete data migration reconciliation before go-live sign-off

Reconcile migrated data against the source system at field level. No go-live should proceed with an unresolved reconciliation break.

Why it matters: Data migration errors discovered after go-live require remediation under live conditions, with users already submitting new transactions. The window for clean remediation closes at go-live.

36 Test the system under peak load conditions

Simulate month-end submission volumes before go-live. Many T&E platforms are sized for average load, not for the spike that occurs in the last three days of the reporting period.

Why it matters: A system that performs well during UAT and degrades at month-end produces user frustration at exactly the moment when finance team pressure is highest.

37 Confirm mobile functionality in every target operating system and version

Test on iOS and Android with the actual device and OS versions used by travellers in each market. Do not assume a platform that works on the current version works on last year's.

Why it matters: A mobile expense app that does not work on a user's device is, from that user's perspective, a broken app. Mobile compatibility is a go-live readiness criterion.

38 Verify SSO and identity management integration before go-live

Test Single Sign-On with the identity provider used in each country. SSO failures at go-live produce immediate help desk volume and rapid user disengagement.

Why it matters: A login problem is the first experience many users have with the new system. A bad first experience is disproportionately difficult to overcome.

39 Complete security and data protection review before go-live

Confirm GDPR compliance for data storage and processing in each country. Verify data residency requirements for countries where these are mandatory.

Why it matters: Data protection issues discovered post-go-live create regulatory exposure and may require system rollback. Discovery before go-live is always preferable.

PHASE 5 — GO-LIVE & HYPERCARE

Items 40–47

40 Stage the rollout — do not launch all countries simultaneously

Launch in one or two pilot markets first. Apply the learnings before rolling out to remaining markets. A phased approach is not slower — it is more reliable.

Why it matters: Simultaneous launches in 10 countries multiply the points of failure. A problem that could be contained in a pilot market becomes a programme-wide incident in a simultaneous rollout.

41 Confirm hypercare team availability for the full committed period

Verify that named hypercare resources — both from the vendor and internally — are confirmed and available. Do not accept 'standard support' as a substitute for hypercare.

Why it matters: Hypercare is only valuable if the people providing it know your specific implementation. A generic support team with no programme context does not constitute hypercare.

42 Run a go/no-go meeting with all workstream leads 48 hours before launch

Review each go-live readiness criterion. Any unresolved critical item is a go-live blocker. Document the outcome and circulate to the steering committee.

Why it matters: A go/no-go meeting 48 hours out creates space to delay launch without emergency conditions. A go/no-go meeting two hours out creates pressure to proceed regardless of readiness.

43 Establish a war room or daily stand-up for the first two weeks post-launch

A daily 15-minute review of adoption metrics, open issues, and escalations. Include the programme owner, local champions, and vendor hypercare lead.

Why it matters: The first two weeks post-launch are when reversion patterns form. Daily visibility over this period allows intervention before patterns become entrenched.

44 Monitor submission rates by country daily for the first 30 days

Any country falling below 70% submission through the new system within 14 days of launch requires active investigation and intervention.

Why it matters: Low submission rates in the first two weeks predict low adoption at 90 days. Early intervention has a significantly higher success rate than late intervention.

45 Communicate the first month-end close in the new system in advance

Send a specific communication to finance teams and approvers explaining what the month-end process looks like in the new system — not a repeat of the general training.

Why it matters: Month-end close is the first high-pressure use of the new system. Users who have not been prepared for how it differs from the old process will revert under pressure.

46 Conduct a 30-day post-launch review with local champions

A structured conversation per market: what is working, what is not, what support is needed, and what should be escalated to the central programme team.

Why it matters: Local champions have information about what is happening on the ground that does not surface in adoption metrics. The 30-day review is the mechanism for capturing it.

47 Schedule the 90-day adoption review before the programme is closed

Commit to a formal adoption review at 90 days post-go-live, with the steering committee, against the adoption metrics agreed before launch. The programme is not closed until this review is complete.

Why it matters: Programmes closed at go-live have no mechanism for catching the adoption drift that begins in weeks three and four. The 90-day review is the minimum accountability structure for realising the business case.

ABOUT THIS RESOURCE

This checklist was compiled by **Mirela Dragulescu**, a finance transformation specialist with 9+ years delivering T&E; platform implementations, corporate card programmes, and change management programmes across 10+ European markets — in four languages, at C-suite level.

The 47 items are drawn from direct programme experience — specifically, the gaps and failures that recur across European implementations regardless of the platform selected. They are not theoretical best practices. They are the things that were missed, or left too late, in programmes that came off the rails.

NEED MORE THAN A CHECKLIST?

If your organisation is planning or managing a T&E; transformation and needs experienced programme management — covering vendor selection, implementation, change management, and adoption — a tailored proposal is available on request.

mdconsulting.netlify.app · dragulescumirela@gmail.com

PREMIUM RESOURCE

The European T&E; Transformation Playbook — the complete end-to-end guide covering vendor selection, programme design, multilingual change management, country-by-country compliance notes, and go-live planning. Includes 5 ready-to-use templates.

Available at mdconsulting.netlify.app/resources